



Crowds turn out to admire Halley's Comet on its appearance in 1835.

1705

Halley's prediction

English astronomer Edmond Halley predicted that a comet he had observed in 1682 would be seen again from Earth in 1758. His prediction proved correct. The comet, which is visible roughly every 75 years, is now known as Halley's Comet.

Mercury thermometer by Fahrenheit, c 1718



“... I dare venture to foretell, That it [the comet] will return again in the Year 1758.”

Edmond Halley, *A Synopsis of the Astronomy of Comets*, 1705

1709

Handy thermometer

Gabriel Fahrenheit, a Polish physicist working in the Netherlands, made the first compact, modern-style thermometer. It had a series of scaled markings and was filled with colored alcohol, which expanded as the temperature rose. Later versions used mercury. Fahrenheit devised the temperature scale named after him in 1724.

1705

1710

1701

Agricultural pioneer

Jethro Tull, an English farmer, invented the mechanical seed drill—a device that planted seeds in neat, evenly spaced rows. His drill wasted much less seed than the traditional method of scattering it by hand. Although Tull's invention did not catch on at first, it would have a key role in modernizing farming.

Sheep and cattle were improved by selective breeding in order to produce more meat.

1708

Porcelain discovery

Porcelain, a bluish-white ceramic imported from China, was extremely popular in Europe, but no one knew how to make it. After 20 years of experimentation, Ehrenfried von Tschirnhaus, a German scientist, found the secret: a paste made of kaolin (a fine white clay) mixed with alabaster.

